

ABEKA SCHOLAR ACADEMY

Middle School Spelling Curriculum

Official Curriculum & Study Material

Chapter 1

Welcome to our advanced study module on English orthography. We have a massive amount of material to cover. Let us begin. English orthography comprises the set of rules used when writing the English language, allowing readers and writers to associate written graphemes with the sounds of spoken English, as well as other features of the language. English's orthography includes norms for spelling, hyphenation, capitalisation, word breaks, emphasis, and punctuation. As with the orthographies of most other world languages, written English is broadly standardised. This standardisation began to develop when movable type spread to England in the late 15th century. However, unlike with most languages, there are multiple ways to spell every phoneme, and most letters also represent multiple pronunciations depending on their position in a word and the context.

This is partly due to the large number of words that have been loaned from a large number of other languages throughout the history of English, without successful attempts at complete spelling reforms, and partly due to accidents of history, such as some of the earliest mass-produced English publications being typeset by highly trained, multilingual printing compositors, who occasionally used a spelling pattern more typical for another language. For example, the word *ghost* was spelled *gost* in Middle English, until the Flemish spelling pattern was unintentionally substituted, and happened to be accepted. Most of the spelling conventions in Modern English were derived from the phonemic spelling of a variety of Middle English, and generally do not reflect the sound changes that have occurred since the late 15th century (such as the Great Vowel Shift).

Despite the various English dialects spoken from country to country and within different regions of the same country, there are only slight regional variations in English orthography, the two most recognised variations being British and American spelling, and its overall uniformity helps facilitate international communication. On the other hand, it also adds to the discrepancy between the way English is written and spoken in any given location.

== Function of letters ==

=== Phonemic representation ===

Letters in English orthography positioned at one location within a specific word usually represent a particular phoneme. For example, *at* consists of 2 letters 'æ' and 't', which represent /æ/ and /t/, respectively. Sequences of letters may perform this role as well as single letters. Thus, in *thrash*, the digraph 'th' (two letters) represents /θ/ and the digraph 'sh' represents /ʃ/. In *hatch*, the trigraph 'tch' represents /tʃ/. Less commonly, a single letter can represent multiple successive sounds. The most common example is 'x', which normally represents the consonant cluster /ks/ (for example, in

tax).

The same letter (or sequence of letters) may be pronounced differently when occurring in different positions within a word. For instance, 'ègh'é represents /f/ at the end of some words (tough) but not in others (plough). At the beginning of syllables, 'ègh'é is pronounced /f/ as in ghost . Conversely, 'ègh'é is never pronounced /f/ in syllable onsets other than in inflected forms, and is almost never pronounced /f/ in syllable codas (the proper name Pittsburgh is an exception). Some words contain silent letters, which do not represent any sound in modern English pronunciation. Examples include the 'èl' in talk, half, calf, etc. , the 'èw' in two and sword, 'ègh'é as mentioned above in numerous words such as though, daughter, night, brought, and the commonly encountered silent 'èe' (discussed further below). === Word origin === Another type of spelling characteristic is related to word origin.

For example, when representing a vowel, 'èy' represents the sound /y/ in some words borrowed from Greek (reflecting an original upsilon), whereas the letter usually representing this sound in non-Greek words is the letter 'èi'. Thus, myth is of Greek origin, while pith is a Germanic word. However, a large number of Germanic words have 'èy' in word-final position, especially when deriving from an Old English -i (modern -y). Some other examples are 'èph' pronounced /f/ (which is most commonly 'èf'), and 'èch' pronounced /k/ (which is most commonly 'èc' or 'èk'). The use of these spellings for these sounds often marks words that have been borrowed from Greek. Some researchers, such as Brengelman (1970), have suggested that, in addition to this marking of word origin, these spellings indicate a more formal level of style or register in a given text, although Rollings (2004) finds this point to be exaggerated as there would be many exceptions where a word with one of these spellings, such as 'èph' for /f/ (like telephone), could occur in an informal text.

Chapter 2

=== Homophone differentiation === Spelling may also be useful to distinguish in written language between homophones (words with the same pronunciation but different meanings), and thus resolve potential ambiguities that would arise otherwise. However in most cases the reason for the difference is historical, and it was not introduced to resolve ambiguity. Examples heir and air are pronounced identically in most dialects, but spelled differently. pain and pane are both pronounced but have two different spellings of the vowel /e/. This arose because the two words were originally pronounced differently: pain used to be pronounced as /peɪn/ with a diphthong, and pane as /peɪn/ but the diphthong /eɪ/ merged with the long vowel /e/ in pane, making pain and pane homophones (pane–pain

merger). Later /e- ð became a diphthong /eɪ/ → break and brake: (She's breaking the car vs. She's braking the car).

Nevertheless, many homophones remain that are unresolved by spelling (for example, the word bay has at least five fundamentally different meanings). === Marking sound changes in other letters === Some letters in English provide information about the pronunciation of other letters in the word. Rollings (2004) uses the term "markers" for such letters. Letters may mark different types of information. 'e' often marks an altered pronunciation of a preceding vowel. In the pair mat and mate, the 'e' of mat has the value /æ/, whereas the 'e' of mate is marked by the 'e' as having the value /eɪ/. In this context, the 'e' is not pronounced, and is referred to as a "silent e". Also, 'e' in once indicates that the preceding 'c' is pronounced /s/, rather than the more common value of 'c' in word-final position as the sound /k/, such as in attic. A single letter may even fill multiple pronunciation-marking roles simultaneously. For example, in the word ace, 'e' marks not only the change of 'a' from /æ/ to /eɪ/ but also of 'c' from /k/ to /s/.

In the word vague, 'e' marks the long 'a' sound, but 'u' keeps the 'g' hard rather than soft. Doubled consonants usually indicate that the preceding vowel is pronounced short. For example, the doubled 't' in batted indicates that the 'a' is pronounced /æ/, while the single 't' of bated gives /eɪ/. Doubled consonants only indicate any lengthening or gemination of the consonant sound itself when they come from different morphemes, as with the 'nn' in unnamed (un+named). === Multiple functionality === Any given letters may have dual functions. For example, 'u' in statue has a sound-representing function (representing the sound /u/) and a pronunciation-marking function (marking the 't' as having the value /t/).

=== Underlying representation === Like many other alphabetic orthographies, English spelling does not represent non-contrastive phonetic sounds (that is, minor differences in pronunciation which are not used to distinguish between different words). Although the letter 't' is pronounced by most speakers with aspiration [t^h] at the beginning of words, this is never indicated in the spelling, and, indeed, this phonetic detail is probably not noticeable to the average native speaker not trained in phonetics. However, unlike some orthographies, English orthography often represents a very abstract underlying representation (or morphophonemic form) of English words. [T]he postulated underlying forms are systematically related to the conventional orthography ... and are, as is well known, related to the underlying forms of a much earlier historical stage of the language.

There has, in other words, been little change in lexical representation since Middle English, and, consequently, we would expect ... that lexical representation would differ very little from dialect to

dialect in Modern English ... [and] that conventional orthography is probably fairly close to optimal for all modern English dialects, as well as for the attested dialects of the past several hundred years. In these cases, a given morpheme (i. e. , a component of a word) has a fixed spelling even though it is pronounced differently in different words. An example is the past tense suffix *-èed'é*, which may be pronounced variously as /t/, /d/, or / {d/ (for example, *pay* , *payed* , *hate* , *hated*). As it happens, these different pronunciations of *-èed'é* can be predicted by a few phonological rules, but that is not the reason why its spelling is fixed.

Chapter 3

Another example involves the vowel differences (with accompanying stress pattern changes) in several related words. For instance, *photographer* is derived from *photograph* by adding the derivational suffix *-'èer'é*. When this suffix is added, the vowel pronunciations change largely owing to the moveable stress: Other examples of this type are the *-'èity'é* suffix (as in *agile* vs. *agility*, *acid* vs. *acidity*, *divine* vs. *divinity*, *sane* vs. *sanity*). See also: Trisyllabic laxing. Another example includes words like *mean* and *meant* , where *'èea'é* is pronounced differently in the two related words. Thus, again, the orthography uses only a single spelling that corresponds to the single morphemic form rather than to the surface phonological form. English orthography does not always provide an underlying representation; sometimes it provides an intermediate representation between the underlying form and the surface pronunciation. This is the case with the spelling of the regular plural morpheme, which is written as either *-'ès'é* (as in *tat*, *tats* and *hat*, *hats*) or *-'èes'é* (as in *glass*, *glasses*).

Here, the spelling *-'ès'é* is pronounced either /s/ or /z/ (depending on the environment, e. g. , *tats* and *tails*) while *-'èes'é* is usually pronounced / {z/ (e. g. *classes* /,†¶Îg1×·¢ò'â Thus, there are two different spellings that correspond to the single underlying representation |z| of the plural suffix and the three surface forms. The spelling indicates the insertion of / {/ before the /z/ in the spelling *-'èes'é*, but does not indicate the devoiced /s/ distinctly from the unaffected /z/ in the spelling *-'ès'é*. The abstract representation of words as indicated by the orthography can be considered advantageous since it makes etymological relationships more apparent to English readers. This makes writing English more complex, but arguably makes reading English more efficient. However, very abstract underlying representations, such as that of Chomsky & Halle (1968) or of underspecification theories, are sometimes considered too abstract to accurately reflect the communicative competence of native speakers.

Followers of these arguments believe the less abstract surface forms are more "psychologically real"

and thus more useful in terms of pedagogy. == Diacritics == Some English words can be written with diacritics; these are mostly loanwords, usually from French. As vocabulary becomes naturalised, there is an increasing tendency to omit the accent marks, even in formal writing. For example, *rôle* and *hôtel* originally had accents when they were borrowed into English, but now the accents are almost never used. The words were originally considered foreign—and some people considered that English alternatives were preferable—but today their foreign origin is largely forgotten. Words most likely to retain the accent are those atypical of English morphology and therefore still perceived as slightly foreign. For example, *café* and *pâté* both have a pronounced final *'èe'é*, which would otherwise be silent under the normal English pronunciation rules. Moreover, in *pâté*, the acute accent is helpful to distinguish it from *pate*.

Further examples of words sometimes retaining diacritics when used in English are: *ångström*—partly because its symbol is *'èÅ'é*—*appliqué*, *attaché*, *blasé*, *bric-à-brac*, *Brötchen*, *cliché*, *crème*, *crêpe*, *fiancé(e)*, *flambé*, *jalapeño*, *naïve*, *naïveté*, *né(e)*, *papier-mâché*, *passé*, *piñata*, *protégé*, *résumé*, *risqué*, and *voilà*. Italics, with appropriate accents, are generally applied to foreign terms that are uncommonly used in or have not been assimilated into English: for example, *adiós*, *belles-lettres*, *crème brûlée*, *pièce de résistance*, *raison d'être*, and *vis-à-vis*. It was formerly common in American English to use a diaeresis to indicate a hiatus, e. g. *coöperate*, *daïs*, and *reëlect*. The *New Yorker* and *Technology Review* magazines still use it for this purpose, even as general use became much rarer. Instead, modern orthography generally prefers no mark (*cooperate*) or a hyphen (*co-operate*) for a hiatus between two morphemes in a compound word. By contrast, use of diaereses in monomorphemic loanwords such as *naïve* and *Noël* remains relatively common.

In poetry and performance arts, accent marks are occasionally used to indicate typically unstressed syllables that should be stressed when read for dramatic or prosodic effect. This is frequently seen with the *-ed* suffix in archaic and pseudoarchaic writing, e. g. *cursèd* indicates the *'èe'é* should be fully pronounced. The grave being to indicate that an ordinarily silent or elided syllable is pronounced (*warnèd*, *parliàment*). == Ligatures == In certain older texts (typically British), the use of the ligatures *'èæ'é* and *'èœ'é* is common in words such as *archæology*, *diarrhœa*, and *encyclopædia*, all of Latin or Greek origin. Nowadays, the ligatures have been generally replaced by the digraphs *'èae'é* and *'èoe'é* (*encyclopaedia*, *diarrhoea*) in British English or just *'èe'é* (*encyclopedia*, *diarrhea*) in American English, though both spell some words with only *'èe'é* (*economy*, *ecology*) and others with *'èae'é* and *'èoe'é* (*paean*, *amoeba*, *oedipal*, *Caesar*).

Chapter 4

In some cases, usage may vary; for instance, both encyclopedia and encyclopaedia are current in the UK. == Phonic irregularities == Partly because English has never had any official regulating authority for spelling, such as the Spanish Real Academia Española, the French Académie française, the German Council for German Orthography, the Danish Sprognævn, and the Thai Royal Society, English spelling is considered irregular and complex compared to that of other languages. Although French, Danish, and Thai, among other languages, present a similar degree of difficulty when encoding (writing), English is more difficult when decoding (reading), as there are clearly many more possible pronunciations of a group of letters.

For example, in French, /u/ (as in "true", but short), can be spelled 'èou, ous, out, oux'é (ou, nous, tout, choux), but the pronunciation of each of those sequences is always the same. However, in English, while /u- ð can be spelled in up to 24 different ways, including 'èoo, u, ui, ue, o, oe, ou, ough, ew'é (spook, truth, suit, blues, to, shoe, group, through, crew) (see Sound-to-spelling correspondences below), all of these spellings have other pronunciations as well (e. g. , foot, us, build, bluest, so, toe, grout, plough, sew). Thus, in unfamiliar words and proper nouns, the pronunciation of some sequences, 'èough'é being the prime example, is unpredictable even for educated native speakers. == Spelling irregularities == Attempts to regularize or reform the spelling of English have usually failed.

However, Noah Webster promoted more phonetic spellings in the United States, such as flavor for British flavour, fiber for fibre, defense for defence, analyze for analyse, catalog for catalogue, and so forth. These spellings already existed as alternatives, but Webster's dictionaries helped standardize them in the United States. (See American and British English spelling differences for details.) Besides the quirks the English spelling system has inherited from its past, there are other irregularities in spelling that make it tricky to learn. English contains, depending on dialect, 24–27 consonant phonemes and 13–20 vowels. However, there are only 26 letters in the modern English alphabet, so there is not a one-to-one correspondence between letters and sounds. Many sounds are spelled using different letters or multiple letters, and for those words whose pronunciation is predictable from the spelling, the sounds denoted by the letters depend on the surrounding letters.

For example, 'èth'é represents two different sounds (the voiced and voiceless dental fricatives) (see Pronunciation of English th), and the voiceless alveolar sibilant can be represented by 'ès'é or 'èc'é. It is, however, not (solely) the shortage of letters which makes English spelling irregular. Its irregularities

are caused mainly by the use of many different spellings for some of its sounds, such as /u- /i- /o/ (too, true, shoe, flew, through; sleeve, leave, even, seize, siege; stole, coal, bowl, roll, old, mould), and the use of identical sequences for spelling different sounds (over, oven, move). Furthermore, English no longer makes any attempt to anglicise the spellings of loanwords, but preserves the foreign spellings, even when they do not follow English spelling conventions like the Polish 'ecz'é in Czech (rather than *Check) or the Norwegian 'èfj'é in fjord (although fiord was formerly the most common spelling).

In early Middle English, until roughly 1400, most imports from French were respelled according to English rules (e. g. bataille–battle, bouton–button, but not double, or trouble). Instead of loans being respelled to conform to English spelling standards, sometimes the pronunciation changes as a result of pressure from the spelling, e. g. ski, adopted from Norwegian in the mid-18th century. It used to be pronounced /('ʃi- /, similar to the Norwegian pronunciation, but the increasing popularity of the sport after the mid-20th century helped the /ski- / pronunciation replace it. There was also a period when the spelling of a small number of words was altered to make them conform to their perceived etymological origins. For example, 'èb'é was added to debt (originally dette) to link it to the Latin debitum, and 'ès'é in island to link it to Latin insula instead of its true origin, the Old English word *īland*. 'èp'é in ptarmigan has no etymological justification whatsoever, only seeking to show Greek origin despite being a Gaelic word. The spelling of English continues to evolve.

Chapter 5

Many loanwords come from languages where the pronunciation of vowels corresponds to the way they were pronounced in Old English, which is similar to the Italian or Spanish pronunciation of the vowels, and is the value the vowel symbols 'èa, e, i, o, u' have in the International Phonetic Alphabet. As a result, there is a somewhat regular system of pronouncing "foreign" words in English, and some borrowed words have had their spelling changed to conform to this system. For example, Hindu used to be spelled Hindoo, and the name Maria used to be pronounced like the name Mariah, but was changed to conform to this system. This only further complicates the spelling, however. On the one hand, words that retained anglicised spellings may be misread in a hyperforeign way. On the other hand, words that are respelled in a 'foreign' way may be misread as if they are English words, e. g. Muslim was formerly spelled Mooslim because of its original pronunciation. Commercial advertisers have also had an effect on English spelling.

They introduced new or simplified spellings like *lite* instead of *light*, *thru* instead of *through*, and *rucsac* instead of *rucksack*. The spellings of personal names have also been a source of spelling innovations: diminutive versions of women's names that sound the same as men's names have been spelled differently: *Nikki* and *Nicky*, *Toni* and *Tony*, *Jo* and *Joe*. The differentiation in between names that are spelled differently but have the same phonetic sound may come from modernisation or different countries of origin. For example, *Isabelle* and *Isabel* sound the same but are spelled differently; these versions are from France and Spain respectively. As an example of the irregular nature of English spelling, 'ough' can be pronounced (depending on vowel mergers) in as many as nine different ways: /aʊ/ in *out*, /oʊ/ in *soul*, /u- / in *soup*, /tʃ/ in *touch*, /k/ in *could*, /f/ in *four*, /ʌ/ in *cough*, and /ə- / in *amorous* (See Spelling-to-sound correspondences).

In the other direction, /i- / can be spelled in at least 18~21 different ways: *be* (*cede*), *ski* (*machine*), *bologna* (GA), *algae*, *quay*, *beach*, *bee*, *deceit*, *people*, *key*, *keyed*, *field* (*hygiene*), *amoeba*, *chamois* (GA), *dengue* (GA), *beguine*, *guyot*, and *ynambu* (See Sound-to-spelling correspondences). (These examples assume a more-or-less standard non-regional British English accent. Other accents will vary.) Sometimes everyday speakers of English change counterintuitive spellings, with the new spellings usually not judged to be entirely correct. However, such forms may gain acceptance if used enough. An example is the word *miniscule*, which still competes with its original spelling of *minuscule*, though this might also be because of analogy with the word *mini*. == 'ough' words == The tetragraph 'ough' can be pronounced in at least ten different ways, six of which are illustrated in the construct, *Though the tough cough and hiccough plough him through*, which is quoted by Robert A. Heinlein in *The Door into Summer* to illustrate the difficulties facing automated speech transcription and reading.

Ough itself is a word, an exclamation of disgust similar to *ugh*, though rarely known or used. The following are typical pronunciations of this string of letters: (as in *so*) in *though* and *dough* (as in *cuff*) in *tough*, *rough*, *enough*, and the name *Hough* (as in *off*) in *trough*, *cough*, and *Gough* (as in *blue*) in *through* (as in *saw*) in *thought*, *ought*, *sought*, *nought*, *brought*, etc. (as in *comma*) in *thorough*, *borough*, and names ending in *-borough*; however, American English pronounces this as (as in *how*) in *bough*, *sough*, *drought*, *plough* (*plow* in North America), *doughty*, and the names *Slough* and *Doughty* (as in *loch*; mainly in words of Gaelic origin) in the word *lough* (an anglicised variant of *loch* used in Ireland) and in Irish place names, such as *Ardclough*, *Glendalough*, *Loughmoe*, *Loughrea*, etc. The following pronunciations are found in uncommon single words: *hough*: (more commonly spelled "hock" now) *hiccough* (a now-uncommon variant of *hiccup*): as in *up Oughterard* (Irish place name): The place name *Loughborough* uses two different pronunciations of 'ough': the

first 'èough'é has the sound as in cuff and the second rhymes with thorough.

== Spelling-to-sound correspondences == Notes: In the tables, the hyphen has two different meanings. A hyphen after the letter indicates that it must be at the beginning of a syllable, e. g. , 'èj'é- in jumper and ajar. A hyphen before the letter indicates that it cannot be at the beginning of a word, e. g. , -'èck'é in sick and ticket. More specific rules take precedence over more general ones, e. g. , "'èc'é- before 'èe, i, y'é" takes precedence over "'èc'é". Where the letter combination is described as "word-final", inflectional suffixes may be added without changing the pronunciation, e. g. , catalogues. The dialects used are Received Pronunciation and General American. When pronunciations differ idiosyncratically, a pronunciation that only applies to one of the dialects is noted as being (RP) or (GA). When pronunciations differ systematically in a way that is not accounted for by the diaphonemic transcription system (i. e. the trap-bath and lot-cloth splits), the pronunciations in both dialects are given. Isolated foreign borrowings are excluded.

Chapter 6

" means the letter is silent === Consonants === Vowels === In a generative approach to English spelling, Rollings (2004) identifies twenty main orthographic vowels of stressed syllables that are grouped into four main categories: "Lax" (similar to the "short" vowels taught in classrooms), "Tense" (the "long vowels"), "Heavy" (their correlated <r>-colored vowel sound), and "Tense-R" (the second and third combined). For instance, 'èa'é can represent the lax vowel , tense , heavy /% Ð/, or tense-r /%²Y. Heavy and tense-r vowels are the respective lax and tense counterparts followed by 'èr'é. Tense vowels are distinguished from lax vowels with a "silent" 'èe'é that is added at the end of words. Thus, 'èa'é in hat is lax , but when 'èe'é is added in the word hate 'èa'é is tense . Heavy and tense-r vowels follow a similar pattern, e. g. 'èar'é in car is heavy , 'èar'é followed by silent 'èe'é in care is . 'èu'é represents two different vowel patterns, one being , the other . There is no distinction between heavy and tense-r 'èo'é, and 'èu'é in the pattern does not have a heavy vowel.

Besides silent 'èe'é, another strategy for indicating tense and tense-r vowels is the addition of another orthographic vowel forming a digraph. In this case, the first vowel is usually the main vowel while the second vowel is the "marking" vowel. For example, man has a lax 'èa'é (), but the addition of 'èi'é (as the digraph 'èai'é) in main marks the 'èa'é as tense (). These two strategies produce words that are spelled differently but pronounced identically, which helps differentiate words that would otherwise be homonyms, as in mane (silent 'èe'é strategy), main (digraph strategy) and Maine (both strategies).

Besides the 20 basic vowel spellings, Rollings (2004) has a reduced vowel category (representing the sounds æ) and a miscellaneous category (representing the sounds ɪ and ʊ , $\text{ɪ}+\text{V}$, $\text{ʊ}+\text{V}$, $\text{V}+\text{V}$).
 Combinations of vowel letters excluding those followed by ə or e To reduce dialectal difficulties, the sound values given here correspond to the conventions at [Help:IPA/English](#).

This table includes h , w , y when they represent vowel sounds. If no information is given, it is assumed that the vowel is in a stressed syllable. Deriving the pronunciation of an English word from its spelling requires not only a careful knowledge of the rules given below (many of which are not explicitly known even by native speakers: speakers merely learn the spelling of a word along with its pronunciation) and their many exceptions, but also: a knowledge of which syllables are stressed and which are unstressed (not derivable from the spelling: compare *hallow* and *allow*) which combinations of vowels represent monosyllables and which represent disyllables (ditto: compare *waive* and *naive*, *creature* and *creator*) The underscore ($_$) in a vowel-consonant- e spelling is the place where the next spelling in a word goes in. The pronunciation of vowel letters when followed by ə or e is covered in a separate table below.

Combinations of vowel letters and ə or e Combinations of other consonant and vowel letters
 Sound-to-spelling correspondences The following table shows for each sound the various spelling patterns used to denote it, starting with the prototypical pattern(s) followed by others in alphabetical order. Some of these patterns are very rare or unique (such as gh for p , ph for v , ei for ɛ). An ellipsis (...) stands for an intervening consonant. Consonants Arranged in the order of the IPA consonant tables. Common Graphemes Rarer graphemes
 Vowels Nasal vowels used by some speakers in words of French origin such as *enceinte* (ɛ), are not included. Rarer Spellings Vowels followed by ə or e Nasal vowels used by some speakers in words of French origin such as *enceinte* (ɛ), are not included.

History Inconsistencies between English pronunciation and English spelling have gradually increased ever since the late medieval and early modern period of English's history, with the greatest changes a consequence of English pronunciation naturally diverging across many centuries, while the spelling often remains frozen in an earlier period. This has resulted in modern English spelling being only somewhat phonetically representative. There are a number of contributing factors to the difficulty of modern orthography but, most importantly, gradual changes in pronunciation, such as the Great Vowel Shift, account for a tremendous number of irregularities or conservative English spellings that persist without accurately reflecting the now-current pronunciations.

Chapter 7

Also, more recent loan words generally carry their original spellings (or spellings that follow transliterations operating according to their own non-English conventions). These loan spellings are thus often not phonetic in English; this includes Romanized words from languages written using non-Roman scripts. The fairly regular spelling system (originally, the runic alphabet, but later the Latin alphabet) of Old English was swept away by the Norman Conquest in 1066, and the English language as a whole was supplanted in some elite spheres by Norman French for three centuries, eventually emerging with its spelling much influenced by the French writing system (with its Latin letters). English also borrowed massive numbers of words from French during this period, and some kept their French spellings regardless of English pronunciation. The spelling in Middle English texts is very variable, since no standardised spelling existed then, with the same word being spelled in different ways by various authors or even the same author, sometimes even in the same sentence.

Instead, spellings at the time were generally meant to more closely resemble the writer's own pronunciation (or accents of the characters they wrote about). For example, /ð/ (normally written 'eu', is spelled with an 'eo' in done, some, love, etc. , due to Norman spelling conventions which prohibited writing 'eu' before 'm, n, v' due to the graphical confusion that would result. ('en, u, v' were written identically with two minims in Norman handwriting; 'ew' was written as two 'eu' letters; 'em' was written with three minims, hence 'emm' looked like 'evun, nvu, uvu', etc.). Similarly, spelling conventions also prohibited final 'ev'. Hence the identical spellings of the three different vowel sounds in love, move, and cove are due to ambiguity in the Middle English spelling system, not sound change. In 1417, Henry V began using English for official correspondence instead of the Latin or French of his predecessors, the latter two languages already having standardised spelling by then.

For instance, Latin had one spelling for right (rectus), Old French as used in English law had six, and Middle English had 77. English spelling gradually settled into a standardised form too, though the process took some 500 years. There was also a series of linguistic sound changes towards the end of the late medieval period, including the Great Vowel Shift, largely responsible for transitioning Middle English into Early Modern English. One such change was the 'ea' in make, name, and case, for example, changing from a pure vowel to a diphthong. These changes for the most part did not detract from the rule-governed nature of the spelling system; but, in some cases, they introduced confusing inconsistencies, like the well-known example of the many pronunciations of 'ough' (tough, through,

though, cough, plough, etc.). Most of these changes happened before the arrival of printing in England.

However, the arrival of the modern printing press in 1476 in some ways froze phonetic spellings of the time, rather than providing the impetus spelling to realign with ever-changing pronunciations. Furthermore, the press introduced further inconsistencies, partly because of the use of typesetters trained abroad, particularly in the Low Countries. For example, the 'èh'é in ghost was influenced by Flemish, whereas the word was often previously spelled gost. The addition and deletion of a silent e at the ends of words was also sometimes used to make the right-hand margin line up more neatly (though many cases of silent e already existed by this time, having been fully pronounced in earlier varieties of Middle English). To make matters more complex, literary scholars in the 17th century sometimes added in silent letters to words merely to hearken back to their Latin origins, such as the b in debt and doubt and the p in receipt, which, though never pronounced, were inserted during this period.

In other instances, scholars even added letters under the mistaken assumption that they were once pronounced or due to mistaken etymologies (such as the relatively recent l in could, meant to mirror the spellings of would and should). As literacy rose, and by the time dictionaries were introduced in the mid-17th century, the spelling system of English was starting to stabilise. Occasionally (though rarely), deliberate initiatives in favour of one spelling or another succeeded. In the early 19th century, for instance, American lexicographer Noah Webster, who published children's spelling books and Webster's Dictionary, was hugely influential at popularising a small number of spelling conventions that solidified in American English but that did not catch on in British English. By the 19th century, most words in the English language had set spellings.

Chapter 8

Even today, the orthographies of British, American, and other dialects of English align for the most part. In *The Mill on the Floss* (1860), English novelist George Eliot satirised the attitude of the English rural gentry of the 1820s towards orthography: Mr. Tulliver did not willingly write a letter, and found the relation between spoken and written language, briefly known as spelling, one of the most puzzling things in this puzzling world. Nevertheless, like all fervid writing, the task was done in less time than usual, and if the spelling differed from Mrs. Glegg's,—why, she belonged, like himself, to a generation with whom spelling was a matter of private judgment. The modern English spelling

system, with its slightly distinct national variants, spread together with the later-19th-century expansion of public education, which has rigorously reinforced a sense of "right" and "wrong" spelling.

